



# RHETORIC - ADVANCED

# WHAT IS RHETORIC?

The background features a light cream color with various abstract organic shapes in orange, teal, yellow, and blue. On the right side, there is a stylized illustration of a brown fruit with green leaves, connected by a thin black line to a small yellow dot. A small blue circle is also visible on the left side.

# WHAT IS RHETORIC?

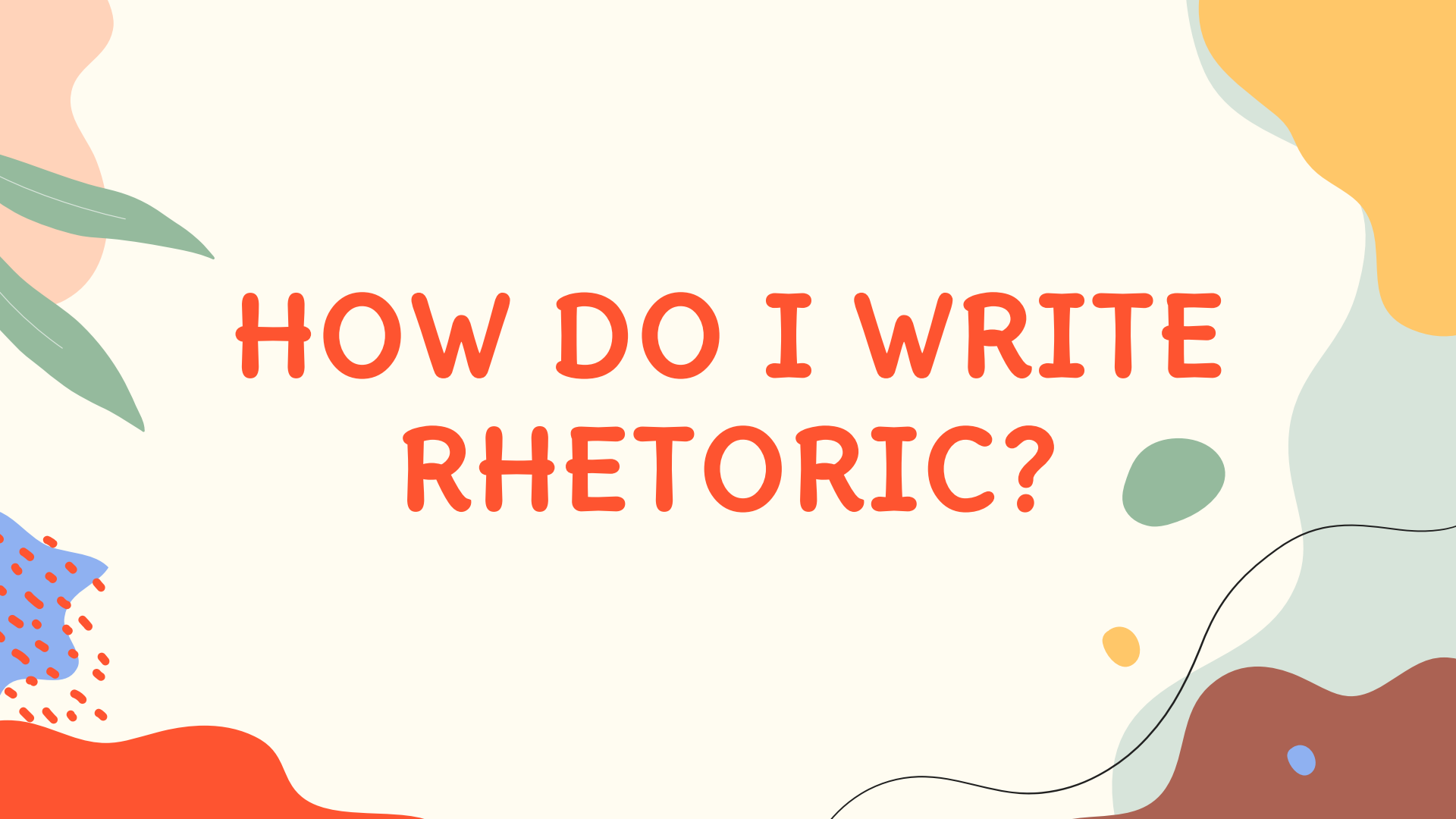
- Rhetoric is a technique of persuasion in public speaking or speech writing.
- Rhetoric can take the form of figures of speech, a metaphor, or a clever one-liner related to the argument you're making.
- In Congress speeches, rhetoric is often used to summarize an argument or paint the picture the argument is conveying.



# WHY IS RHETORIC important?

# WHY IS RHETORIC IMPORTANT?

- In Congress, your goal as a debater is to persuade the judges to believe your argument and want to side with you the most.
- Rhetoric also allows you to paint the picture of the scenario you are arguing will happen if a bill is or is not passed. This allows your argument to more heavily reside with the judges by making it more memorable and easy to understand.
- Utilize rhetoric to show the real world/human impact of your argument

The background features a variety of abstract, organic shapes in muted colors: orange, green, blue, and red. There are also small, scattered dots and a thin black line. The text is centered in a bold, orange, sans-serif font.

# HOW DO I WRITE RHETORIC?

# HOW DO I WRITE/USE RHETORIC?

- **STEP 1: Pick A Theme**

- Your speech should follow a rhetorical theme, introduced by your intro and concluded by your conclusion
- Your theme should be an idea related to congress that you can apply to your argument
- Here are some examples of some good basic themes:  
Light & Dark, Time: Past, Present & Future, Physical actions:  
Sitting/Standing/Seeing/Hearing, American Values like  
Freedom, etc.
- Your theme should develop throughout the speech, like a story.

# HOW DO I WRITE/USE RHETORIC?

- **STEP 2: Introduce your theme**

- After you've chosen your theme, it's important to understand how you will use it to advance your argument.
- Here's an example: Let's say you've chosen 'Time' as your theme
- First introduce the theme and how it relates to your argument

EX: "In the 4 years I have served this congress, I have utterly lost count of how many times I've heard the phrase 'democracy dies in darkness'. But the ironic thing is that not once have we ever stopped to consider what exactly that darkness looks like. For the least fortunate in this nation, it looks like living a life knowing you will never be seen, heard, and will inevitably be forgotten by this congress. After hundreds of years, it's time we finally shed light."

- This establishes the primary issue you will be discussing and the change you will be advocating for.



# HOW DO I WRITE/USE RHETORIC?

- **STEP 3: Use theme to advance your argument**
- After you've introduced your theme, you'll now have to contextualize it to your argument throughout your speech
- Here's an example: Let's say you've just established the problem in the status quo that your argument discusses. You should conclude this section of your speech with a line of rhetoric.  
Ex: "I'm not willing to let past inaction be used as an excuse for future inaction. The consequence is always inequity in our democracy."
- Effectively use your rhetoric as a conclusion to one section of your speech as well as a transition to the next.

# HOW DO I WRITE/USE RHETORIC?

- **STEP 4: Show the solution**
- The next part of your speech should establish the solvency your argument provides.
- At this point, all you need is a quick one-liner to show how this section of the speech has advanced your theme.
- Ex: *"This finally gives politicians the incentive they need to listen to the Americans that have been silenced, and pass policies for them that are salient."*
- This should be followed up by a rhetorical question to set up your impacts. I.e. "So what happens then?" "Why is that so vital?"

# HOW DO I WRITE/USE RHETORIC?

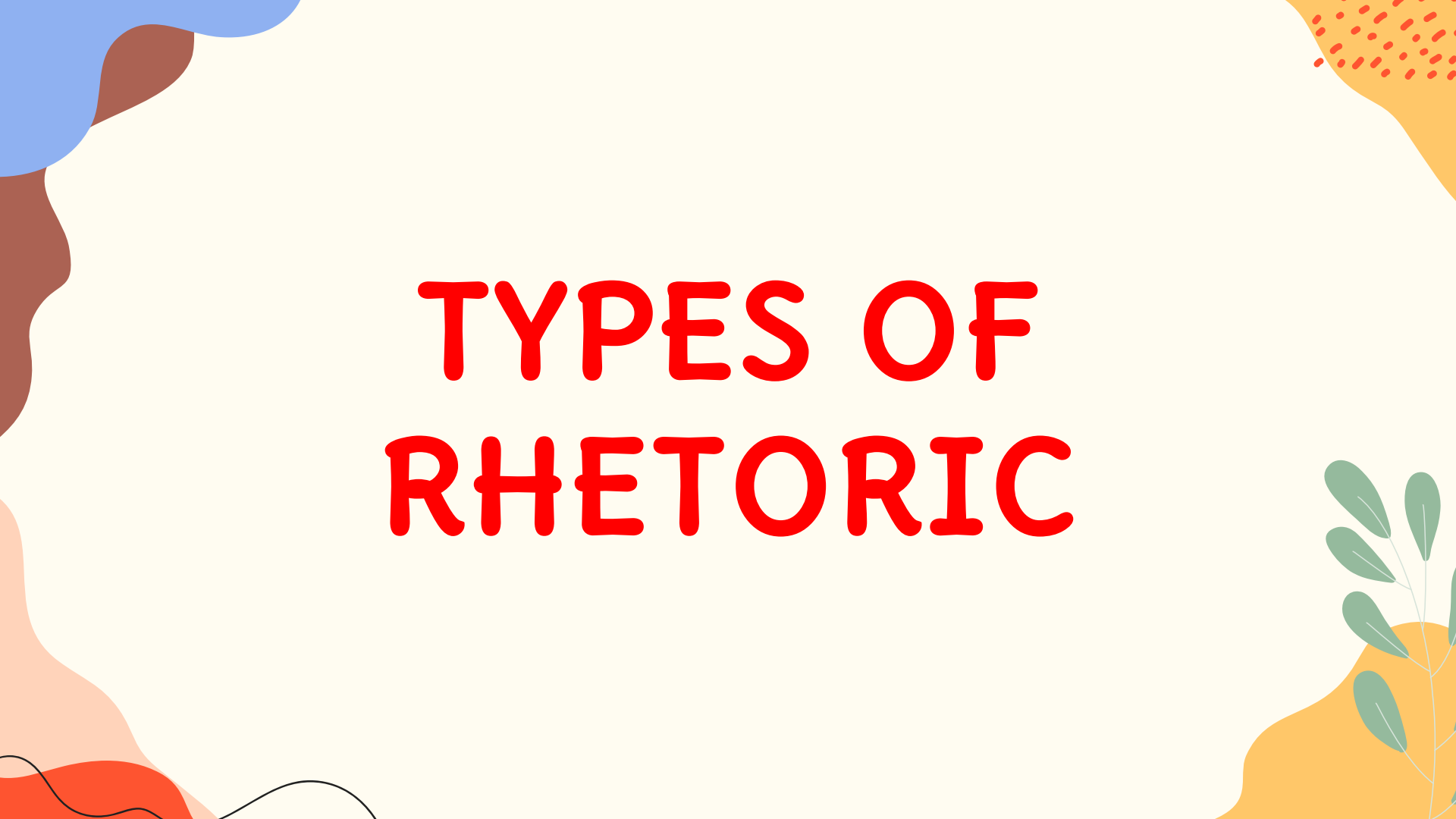
- **STEP 5: Paint the picture**
- Once you establish your impact(s), use your rhetorical theme to really quantify what the world your advocating for looks like, and how it compares to the status quo
- Ex: "Giving Americans a voice that matters ensures they do not feel so powerless as to have to take matters into their own hands."
- Remember to use detail, be fluid/catchy, and utilize emotion.

# HOW DO I WRITE/USE RHETORIC?

- **STEP 6: End the story**
- Now that you've laid out the whole argument, conclude your rhetorical theme to solidify the scenario you're painting for the judges
- "Living in the dark, forces Americans to feel they have no choice but to take the darkest paths. As I leave this congress as a memory of the past, I ask you one last time to give Americans a brighter future."
- By the end of your speech, the world you've established through your rhetorical theme should be clear and easy to understand.

# HOW DO I WRITE/USE RHETORIC?

- **CONGRATULATIONS!**
- You now know how to effectively write and use rhetoric to advance your advocacy
- We've mainly discussed affirmative rhetorical strategy, but don't worry! Just keep the mindset of comparing worlds. When on the negation, simply use your rhetoric in the same format but with the goal of showing that the legislation you're discussing creates a worse scenario than the status quo, instead of better.

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# TYPES OF RHETORIC

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Here are the most common/effective types of rhetoric you can utilize:

- **Emotional**
  - Picture painting
  - Change/action advocacy
  - Morality
- **Comical**
  - One-liners
  - Pop-culture references
  - Comparative jokes
- **Personal Anecdotes**
  - Personal experiences
  - Someone else's personal stories

# TYPES OF RHETORIC (EMOTIONAL)

- Emotional rhetoric is designed to be delivered emotionally with the goal of sparking an emotional reaction from the audience.
- **This is often done by painting the picture...**
  - Ex: "when the energy grid is on the verge of falling apart, it's not just light flickering here and there, it means everytime you turn on a lamp, money is siphoned out of your pocket. Damaged roads doesn't just mean every car ride is bumpy, it means ur prone to fatal crashes. Lack of internet doesn't just mean you can't watch Disney+, it means you can't connect with the rest of the world."
- **Or maybe advocating for action...**
  - Ex: "Today, America can finally live up to what we have been calling ourselves for centuries. A global leader. What does it mean to be that leader? It means to stand in the face of adversity and to soar above it. It means to reach for the stars in spite of our fears. And it means doing whatever it takes to protect the people we promised to. What can we do for our country? Let's let the answer be an affirmation victory."
- **Or sometimes a question of morality:**
  - Ex: "At the end of this debate, the question is very simple: Who do you serve? I think our answer should be clear. Affirm."



# TYPES OF RHETORIC (COMICAL)

- The goal of comical rhetoric is to make yourself seem relatable/knowledgeable. This makes the judge more inclined to want to side with you
- **This can take the form of a one-liner...**
  - Ex: "This congress is like mice. So focused on the cheese, that we keep forgetting about the trap."
    - (context: this is from an argument about money in politics - the 'cheese' represents the money, and the 'trap' represents whatever issue keeps getting overlooked.)
- **Or a pop-culture reference...**
  - "This debate has just been the biggest 'will they, won't they' since Ross and Rachel."
    - Reference to a popular show, artist, celebrity that most people will know.
- **Or a comparative joke:**
  - "Letting this congress approve election results makes about as much sense as letting the 49ers decide who gets to referee today's game"
    - (context: this is from a debate that took place on the same day as a 49er playoff game. References to recent or even current events are a good way to seem personable.)

# TYPES OF RHETORIC (PERSONAL ANECDOTES)

- Personal anecdotes can be an effective way to show a real world application of a problem or solution
- **This can be from your personal life...**
  - *"During the wave of hate crimes, countless Asian American households, including my own were scared to even go outside."* - **Charlie Gu**
- **Or it can be someone else's story...**
  - "John was deeply entrenched in an extremist rabbit hole, but being exposed to the views of the other side saved him."
    - If you are going to use someone else's story, make it clear that it is not an obscure case, and that there are many more just like it.

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# RHETORICAL STRATEGIES

# RHETORICAL STRATEGIES: AUDITORY

This is probably the easiest kind of rhetoric because it relies on concepts most of us learn in school and have practiced before. Also, it's the least time consuming.

## A. Alliteration

. For far too long this Congress has protected the powerful, the privileged, and the prosperous over the marginalized and the oppressed.

There's shit in the shower.

## B. Rhyming

In the name of furthering American glory, we trample on innocent lives and their story.

# RHETORICAL STRATEGIES: STRUCTURE

This is probably the hardest kind of rhetoric and thus, the most impressive. It relies on the use of words in either the same or opposite order from the first part of the sentence to the second.

## A. Parallel

Innocents need a life line; Don't put their lives on the line

## B. Reverse

Innocents need a life line; Don't draw a line through their lives

In a country that ignores discrimination in broad daylight, democracy will never see the light of day.

# RHETORICAL STRATEGIES: PAIRED IDEAS

## A. Complimentary

We live in a country where every voice, every vote, and everyone, matters.

A breath of fresh air and a sip of clean water should never be a luxury, but a human right.

## B. Opposing

For far too long, we've met our "enemies" with a closed fist. It's time to offer a helping hand.

# RHETORICAL STRATEGIES: DESCRIPTION

## A. Imagery

Immigration detainment centers are filled not with hope, but with children sleeping on concrete floors, separated from their families with nothing but the clothes on their backs to keep warm.

## B. Common phrases

Nobody should ever have to choose between having food on the table or a roof over their heads.

# RHETORICAL STRATEGIES: COMBOS!

The most effective rhetoric usually employs two or more strategies.

Rhyming + Alliteration:

This legislation isn't a lifeline. It just leads to flatlines — in hospital after hospital, heartbeat after heartbeat.

Parallel + Opposing ideas:

While we build windmills hundreds of feet above the ground, exploited children mine the minerals for it hundreds of feet below.

Complimentary Ideas + Rhyming:

I refuse to stay silent in a world where my mother, my sisters, and my daughters live with a target on their backs every day, who will never be seen as anything more than easy prey.



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some THINGS TO  
keep IN MIND

# some THINGS TO KEEP IN MIND

- When writing rhetoric, avoid the following:
  - Explicit language
  - Vulgar/Graphic content
  - Going into detail about a person(s)'s suffering (this can come across as exploitation)
- Also do your best to avoid:
  - Common rhetoric that has been overused
    - Ex: "Progress is the opposite of Congress" "Road to hell is paved with good intentions", etc.
    - This can make you seem less unique as a debater, and make the judges bored or uninterested.
- Always try to write rhetoric that is worded in a way that's authentic to you. Try not to over-do it by trying to be a "master poet", as this can make you seem disingenuous. Be yourself!

# some THINGS TO KEEP IN MIND

- The goal of rhetoric is to be catchy and memorable, some good ways to do this are through rhythm and alliteration
  - Ex: "This goes against equality and equity and never should've happened"
    - This is very basic. Here's how to make it more memorable:
  - "This is not equity, this is not equality. This is an atrocity."
  - "How will you be remembered: As the policy maker who upheld their promise to to protect their people. Or not at all, when there's no one left to know your name"
  - Johnny Cochran OJ Trial: "If the glove don't fit, you must acquit!"
- Be catchy, be creative

# some THINGS TO keep in mind

Rhetoric should not tokenize marginalized groups or rely on graphically depicted people's pain for the sake of a ballot. Rhetoric is real. The people you are fighting for are real. Always remember:

Behind every number is a name, behind every statistic is a story, and behind every percentage point lies a person.

(Alliteration + parallel + common phrases)